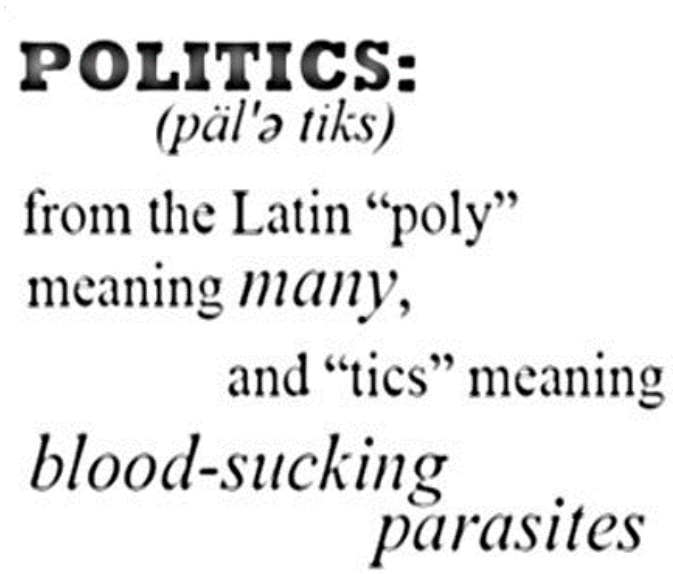
Conducting Social Science

August 24, 2022

Political Science and Subfields

The study of power, its distribution, and its consequences.

- American Politics
- Comparative Politics
- International Politics
- Political Theory



Studying Politics Scientifically

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Science: *"The Goal is Inference and the Content is the Method"*

- Questions
- Models / Theories
- Implications
- Empirical Testing
- Evaluate Theory

Questions

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- Empirical- Questions about how the world is.
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The "best" questions are puzzling... the answer isn't immediately obvious.

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We build theories from concepts and test them with variables.

Theories

"Theories are no more or less than a priori reasoning about the relations among variables" (Bueno de Mesquita 1981)

Essential Characteristics of Theories:

- Explanation of phenomena that can vary
- Logically consistent
- Non-tautological
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- Accurate*

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*Theories often require simplifying assumptions, and that's okay, if they are plausible

Implications and Hypotheses

If our theory is correct, what should we observe?

- Hypothesis: A statement specifying a predicted and systematic pattern between **X** and **Y**
  - Positive relationship (+)
  - Negative relationship (-)

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Testable Hypothesis 1: Democratic countries are less likely to go to war with each other.

Testing Hypotheses...

Qualitative Analysis: In-depth examination of one or a few cases

- Trace a specific process to determine "cause" and "effect"
- "Thick" descriptions of phenomena
- Exploratory probe
- Better for developing theory than testing it

Quantitative Analysis: Transforming concepts into numerical data and studying those data

- Use statistics and graphs to evaluate patterns
- Make generalizable claims
- Requires precise measurement of concepts
- Sacrifices deep case analyses for broader conclusions

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Challenging Theory- try to prove it *wrong*, not *right*

- Verify the logic
- Test the hypothesis in different contexts/samples
- Test the hypothesis with a better design/bigger datasets/more accurate data
- Derive additional hypotheses and test them
- Develop and evaluate other equally logical explanations for the observed pattern

Democratic Peace Again

Theory: Democratic countries create domestic norms of peaceful contention among the population. People in these countries therefore use violence as a last resort, preferring instead to compromise and negotiate.

Testable Hypothesis 1: Democratic countries are less likely to go to war with each other.

Testable Hypothesis 2: Democratic countries are less likely to go to war at all, compared to autocratic countries.

“Good” Theory

- Generalizable - apply to many contexts or settings
- Parsimonious - simple and require few assumptions or constraints
- Fertile - can produce lots of testable implications
- Surprising - produces interesting implications that aren’t obvious from assumptions

Next Class

- Tuesday, August 30- Research Design and Causation
- Read: KW Chapter 4